

After the Story: More Than a Teacher

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A companion study to *Every Exit Reopens*

Back to the Packerton Sheds

Go back out with me to the Packerton transfer sheds west of Jim Thorpe. Old Lehigh Valley Railroad classification ground gone to weeds and pigeons, brick and corrugated iron in a broken line, concrete pads that still hold grit and dry cement dust. Cal Merritt was twenty-three that night. He is twenty-seven now. He ran with Quinn Harlow half a stride left and a fifty-pound bag of Portland mix already burning his forearms through the work gloves, because a once-human platform clerk in a faded coat had stepped out from between two dead gondolas and started after them without calling their names.

You remember how it went. They left bay doors open chasing a raccoon on a pallet rack. Then the clerk came on with boots that hit gravel in a meter no tired man uses, and every door they shut swung open again behind them. Quinn hauled the chain on bay three. The roll-up stuck, then slammed, then refused the sill. The latch bar danced in a shallow socket. The clerk's long fingers closed on the bottom rail from their side of the apron and said the exits stay open.

Cal could have kept talking. Aunt Della had given him three short lines on her back steps the summer he turned seventeen: Jesus, hold the latch. Shut what wants back in. Keep my hands on the weight. He put the short work into the air while his boots moved. When the rail rose against his palms, he shut his mouth and stacked. Cinder blocks two high, three deep at the center. Bags of mix wedged against the personnel door. Quinn bent a hitch pin through the hasp with the heel of her glove. Weight held what speech alone could not finish. When Cal put the short work back while his hands stayed on the top block, the clerk's pull failed and the coat walked back into the dark between the sheds.

Later, on Aunt Della's porch, the combination square her late husband left on the table still lay where he had set it, brass and steel, dull with shop oil. Della washed the grit out of Cal's palms. Soft, she said a good teacher can tell you how to cut a joint, and a Person can hold a door when your hands are already on the weight, and those are not the same claim. Quinn stood by the rail

and granted the stop at the door. She would not grant a Person on the other end of the three lines. She still sits across from Cal at the diner on Broadway in Jim Thorpe and argues that prayer is a noise useful people make when a latch sticks. He keeps three spare hitch pins in the glove box. He does not preach the door at her. He checks that bay three still falls true.

That is the question tonight. Not whether a latch can stick. Whether the One named in the short work is only a teacher who gives good advice about joints, or a Person who can hold a door when the weight is already in your hands.

Questions to Sit With

1. Read 1 John 4:1-3. John tells the church to test the spirits, and he marks the difference between a confession that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh and a spirit that will not confess Him. Cal said the short work while his boots moved and his hands found the blocks. Quinn granted the stop and kept the file open on who answered. What is the difference between using lines that work and confessing a Person who came in the flesh?
2. Read Mark 6:3, where the people of Jesus's own town call Him the carpenter, the son of Mary, and take offense at Him. Then read John 14:6, where Jesus says He is the way and the truth and the life, and that no one comes to the Father except through Him. Aunt Della kept a carpenter's tools on the table and still refused to flatten the claim to shop talk. Why does a carpenter's trade not settle who Jesus is? What happens if we leave Him on the shelf as a teacher only?
3. Read Matthew 16:15, where Jesus asks His disciples who they say He is. Then read John 8:58 and John 10:30, where Jesus claims the Name before Abraham and says He and the Father are one. Quinn will grant the stop at the door and will not grant the Person. Cal will not force the porch on her, and he will not leave the latch untested. Where are you standing on that same question tonight?

The Teaching: More Than a Teacher

Start where the story starts. With grit on a loading pad, a roll-up track cold under both hands, and a bag of mix cutting into your arms. Packerton is not a classroom. It is sheds and leftover blocks and a personnel door that will not stay shut until bags brace the threshold. Every tool in that bay

was made for work: latch bar, floor socket, hitch pin, combination square on Della's table. The whole night runs on knowing what a door is and what weight will do.

That is why Della's porch line is the right one. A good teacher can tell you how to cut a joint. A Person can hold a door when your hands are already on the weight. Those are not the same claim.

Josh McDowell and his son Sean McDowell wrote a whole book under that pressure, and they titled it with the same refusal to leave Jesus on the shop shelf. In *More Than a Carpenter* they put the claim plain: "Jesus claimed to be God, and to him it was of fundamental importance that men and women believed him to be who he was." (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3 Lord, Liar, or Lunatic?). They go on: "Either we believe him, or we don't. He didn't leave us any wiggle room for in-between, watered-down alternatives." (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3 Lord, Liar, or Lunatic?).

Cal stood on that same ground with gray powder on his boots. The short work he said was a claim about who Jesus is. Either that is true or it is empty noise useful people make when a latch sticks. If it is empty, Della taught him three lines the way a shop boss teaches a cut list. If it is true, the clerk who needed open mouths met a latch held by more than iron and Portland mix.

The McDowells walk the options without soft landings. If Jesus claimed to be God and knew He was not, He was a liar, and a liar who sent people to stake their lives on a false Name. But the life does not fit the charge. "Someone who lived as Jesus lived, taught as Jesus taught, and died as Jesus died could not have been a liar." (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3 Lord, Liar, or Lunatic?).

Then the second option. Maybe He believed it and was wrong. The McDowells admit that out loud: "After all, it's possible to be both sincere and wrong." (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3 Lord, Liar, or Lunatic?). But a man who sincerely and wrongly believed Himself to be God, in a fiercely monotheistic culture that would kill a man for saying so, would not be a sound teacher of joints and morals. He would be out of His mind. And nobody who reads the Gospels comes away thinking the Sermon on the Mount was written by a madman.

So we come to the third. The McDowells quote C. S. Lewis, who put the choice as hard as anyone ever has: "You can shut Him up for a fool, you can spit at Him and kill Him as a demon,

or you can fall at His feet and call Him Lord and God." (C. S. Lewis, quoted in McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3 Lord, Liar, or Lunatic?). And then they close the easy exit: "You cannot put him on the shelf merely as a great moral teacher or a prophet. That is not a valid option. He is either a liar, a lunatic, or Lord and God." (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3 Lord, Liar, or Lunatic?).

Now look at Packerton through that window.

Cal answered with his hands on the cargo. He ran the short work while his boots moved. When the rail rose and breath ran short, he stacked blocks and bags instead of making a speech in the dark. When the weight sat, he put the lines back into the air with his palms still on the top course. That is not a man treating prayer like a lucky noise. That is a man trusting a Person enough to keep his hands on the weight while he asks that Person to hold the latch.

Quinn answered with an open file. She saw a dead clerk's coat try to pull a roll-up out of a concrete sill. She bent the hitch pin. She granted the stop at the door. She would not grant the Person before a bandage and a beer, and four years later she still will not grant Him across the diner table on Broadway. The McDowells would not scold her for wanting evidence. They would say the file cannot stay open forever on the watered-down shelf: "Your decision about Jesus must be more than an idle intellectual exercise." (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3 Lord, Liar, or Lunatic?).

Della answered years before that night. She was a carpenter's widow who kept tools because tools remember work better than talk does. She taught Cal three lines on the back steps and told him to say them while his feet kept moving. On the porch she washed his palms and refused to flatten Jesus into a shop tip. Soft, she drew the line Quinn still will not cross: teacher and Person are not the same claim.

Notice one more thing. The story lets Quinn keep her open file and still makes her grant the stop. The blocks held. The bags held. The hitch pin held. Evidence closed one side door and left the main question standing: who held the latch with them? A good teacher can tell you how to cut a joint. A Person can hold a door when your hands are already on the weight. The McDowells wrote a book to keep us from confusing those two claims. Packerton puts the same choice on a concrete apron after dark.

Around the Fire: Talk It Over and Take It Home

Talk about Cal's hands. He said the short work while he ran. He went quiet to stack. He put the lines back when the weight sat. Where in your life have you talked about the latch and left the blocks on the tarp? Where have you stacked without asking the Person to hold what your hands already bear?

Talk about Quinn. She is honest in one hard way. She will grant what she saw at the door and she will not pretend she has settled who answered. Read Matthew 16:15 again. Who do you say He is? What is the diner table you keep using so you can grant the stop and refuse the Person?

Talk about Aunt Della. She kept a combination square on the table and a porch sentence that will not shrink. Who in your life has been a Della, someone who washed grit out of your hands and refused to let you flatten Jesus into advice? Have you thanked that person? Have you argued past them the way Quinn argued past the porch?

Talk about the cargo. Cinder blocks and Portland bags finished what a speech alone could not. Faith in this story is not a speech contest. It is hands on the weight and a Name in the air at the same time. What concrete work is in front of you this week that needs both?

Try this, this week. Read 1 John 4:1-3, Mark 6:3, John 14:6, Matthew 16:15, John 8:58, and John 10:30 out loud, slow, with a pencil in your hand. At the top of a page write MORE THAN A TEACHER. Under it write three words in a column: LIAR, LUNATIC, LORD. Next to each one, write honestly what it would mean for your life if that one were true. Then do what Quinn has not done yet at the Broadway diner. Answer the question. Answer it out loud, to God, in your own plain words, rough and short if that is all you have. Then get your hands on the weight in front of you and keep them there while you ask Him to hold the latch.

Works Cited

McDowell, Josh, and Sean McDowell. *More Than a Carpenter*. Revised and updated edition. Carol Stream, IL: Tyndale House Publishers, 2009.